Mapping Empire: A Distant Viewing Approach to News Maps in Victorian Illustrated Periodicals, 1842-1890

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On 24th July 1886, *The Graphic* published the Imperial Federation League Map for the Colonial and Indian Exhibition (Figure 1). The map outlines areas of the British Empire surrounded by iconography of peoples across the world. The figure Britannia regally sits on a globe, labelled 'world', indicating her position of authority (Crane 1886). To quote Driver, this map is 'an excellent candidate for the quintessentially imperial map' (Driver 2010). The map may be an example of a news map which has shaped the public imagination of the British Empire, but it is not the only one. The illustrated periodical press boomed during the nineteenth-century, creating a visual image of the empire for its readers prior to the rise of press photography. In this paper, we propose to take a distant viewing approach to look at many maps from different illustrated periodicals that collectively contributed to the imperial geography of the British Empire.

In this research, we utilise the multimodal embeddings which we created in our previous project (RSPV 2024) to identify a total of 767 maps from three leading illustrated periodicals of the nineteenth-century in Britain during the period 1842-1890: the *Illustrated London News, The Graphic,* and the *Illustrated Times*, and cluster them into visually similar groups (see, for example, Figures 2 and 3 which contain maps of specific places, in this case London and Delhi respectively).[1] Building on the MapReader library, we extract ca. 176.000 possible toponyms from these maps, which we plan to use to create a 'maps of maps' of the British Empire in the nineteenth-century periodical press (Wood et al. 2024a, Wood et al. 2024b). Conceptually, we argue that these maps functioned at the meeting point of two cartographic genres, news maps and imperial cartography. As news maps, they, as Monmonier argues, functioned to 'reflect the objectives and values of journalistic institutions', being highly selective in what they chose to represent of the world (Monmonier 1989). They also function as a form of imperial cartography, which Heffernan argues during this period showed the (potential) colonies as spaces of adventure and risk (Heffernan 2009). Together, the intersection of news maps and imperial cartography functions as a starting point to research the contribution of the illustrated periodical press to the public imaginary of the British Empire for its readers.

Figure 1: Walter Crane, The Imperial Federation League Map for the Colonial and Indian Exhibition, published as a supplement to *The Graphic*, 24 July 1886.

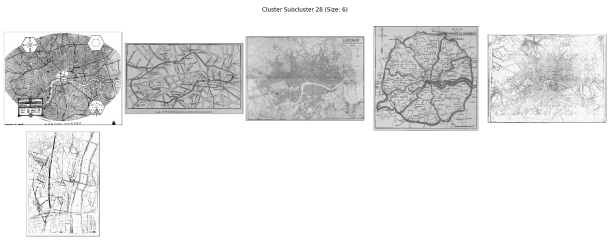

Figure 2: Subcluster 28, showing primarily maps of London

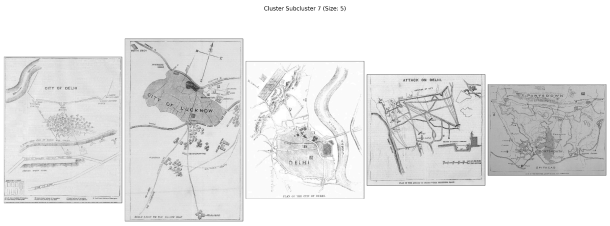

Figure 3: Subcluster 7, showing primarily maps of Delhi

Notes

1. For more information on our use of clustering algorithms and dimension selection, see: Smits, Thomas/ Paklons, Elenora (2024). “ Optimizing Multimodal Clustering (of 10,000 Magic Lantern Slides)”. Digital Humanities Benelux 2024 Conference. https://doi.org/10.5281/ZENODO.11445566.

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Imperial Federation Map of the World Showing the Extent of the British Empire in 1886 (24 June 1886). Cornell University – PJ Mode Collection of Persuasive Cartography. https://digital.library.cornell.edu/catalog/ss:3293793 .

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